

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1988-05-31

1 dear b ahá'í f riends,

we have been informed of a paper presented at a recent New zealand

2 bahá'í Studies conference, which raises the possibility that the ineligibility
3 temporary provision subject to change through a process of progressive un-
4 foldment of the divine purpose. we present the following points as a means
5 of increasing the friends' understanding of this established provision of the
6 confined to men.

The system of bahá'í Administration is "indissolubly bound with the

7 essential verities of the faith" as set forth in the writings of bahá'u'lláh
8 and 'Abdu'l-b ahá. A unique feature of this system is the appointment of
9 authorized interpreters, in the persons of 'Abdu'l-b ahá and the guardian,
10 to provide authoritative statements on the intent of bahá'u'lláh's revelation.
11 writing in "The dispensation of bahá'u'lláh," Shoghi effendi stated that
12 'Abdu'l-b ahá and the guardian "share . . . the right and obligation to inter-
13 pret the bahá'í teachings." in relation to his own function as interpreter, he
14 further stated that "the guardian has been specifically endowed with such
15 power as he may need to reveal the purport and disclose the implications of the
utterances of bahá'u'lláh and of 'Abdu'l-b ahá."

16 52-1 The significance

17 of this important provision is that the religion of god is safeguarded and
18 protected against schism and its essential unity is preserved.

19 The function of the divinely appointed interpreters is evident in the pro-
20 gressive disclosure and clarification of the details of the bahá'í teachings
21 houses of justice. however, in many of his laws he refers simply to "the
22 house of justice" and its members as "m en of justice," leaving open for
23 later clarification to which level or levels of the whole institution each law

24 52-1. wob, p. 151.52.1

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53 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

54 88would apply. ‘Abdu’l-b ahá, the center of bahá’u’lláh’s covenant and the

55 unerring interpreter of his word, not only provided for the establishment

56 of National Spiritual Assemblies, to be designated at some future time as

57 Secondary houses of justice, but he also outlined the means by which the

58 universal house of justice was to be elected. in his will and Testament the

59 master wrote:

And now, concerning the house of justice which god hath or-

60 dained as the source of all good and freed from all error, it must be elected by
universal suffrage, that is, by the believers. . . . by this

a secondary house of justice must be instituted, and these secondary

61 houses of j ustice must elect the members of the u niversal one. . . .

(p. 1)

62 And in one of h is Tablets h e had already written:

At whatever time all the beloved of god in each country appoint

63 their delegates, and these in turn elect their representatives, and these representatives
elect a body, that body shall be regarded as the Su-preme h ouse of j ustice.

64 52-2

in the following passage, ‘Abdu’l-b ahá referred to membership of the

65 “house of justice” being restricted to men, without a specific designation

66 of the level or levels of the institution to which this provision applied:

The house of justice, however, according to the explicit text of the

67 law of god, is confined to men; this for a wisdom of the lord god’s,

68 which will ereelong be made manifest as clearly as the sun at high noon.

(Selections from the Writings of ‘ Abdu’l-Bahá, p. 8052-3)

69 52-2. cc 1:322.

70 52-3. Sw Ab, no. 38.4.52.3a

52 3b

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3c

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whose membership was confined to men. ‘Abdu’l-b ahá wrote:

According to the ordinances of the faith of god, women are

the equals of men in all rights save only that of membership on the

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universal house of justice, for as hath been stated in the text of the

book, both the head and the members of the house of justice are

men. however, in all other bodies, such as the Temple construction

committee, the Teaching committee, the Spiritual Assembly, and in

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charitable and scientific associations, women share equally in all rights

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with men.

(from a newly translated Tablet)

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Shoghi effendi, in a letter written on his behalf to an individual believer,

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provided the following authoritative elaboration of this theme:

As regards your question concerning the membership of the uni-

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versal house of justice: there is a Tablet from ‘Abdu’l-b ahá in which

he definitely states that the membership of the universal house is

confined to men, and that the wisdom of it will be fully revealed and

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appreciated in the future. in the local as well as the National houses

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of justice, however, women have the full right of membership. it is,

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therefore, only to the international house that they cannot be elected.

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...

(28 july 196)

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‘Abdu’l-b ahá himself, it should also be noted, had, as attested by the

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above-cited extracts from his Tablets, affirmed that the ineligibility of

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the text of the book” and “in the explicit text of the law of god.” in

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other words, this provision was established by none other than bahá’u’lláh

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himself.

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further, in response to a number of questions about eligibility for mem-

71 guardian's secretary writing on his behalf distinguished between those
72 questions which could be answered by reference to the "explicitly revealed"

Text and those which could not. membership of the universal house of

justice fits into the former category. The letter stated:52.3d

52 4

52 4a

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52 6

53 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

men. fixing the number of the members, the procedures for election

and the term of membership will be known later, as these are not

54 explicitly revealed in the h o l y T e x t.

(27 m a y 190)

55 hence, 'Abdu'l-b ahá and the guardian progressively have revealed, in accor-

56 dance with divine inspiration, the meaning and implications of bahá'u'lláh's

57 seminal teachings. Their interpretations are fundamental statements of truth which
cannot be varied through legislation by the universal house

58 of justice.

59 The progressive clarification of the details of the laws concerning mem-

60 bership of the houses of justice has been accompanied by a gradual imple-

61 mentation of their provisions. for example, based on the Texts available

62 to the believers at the time, membership of local houses of justice was

63 initially confined to men. when the master began to elaborate on the differ-

64 ences between the levels of this institution he clarified that the exclusion of

65 became eligible for service as members of local and National Spiritual As-

66 semblies. women in the west, who already enjoyed the benefits of educa-

67 tion and opportunities for social involvement, participated in this form of service
much sooner than, for instance, their bahá'í sisters in iran, who were

68 accorded this right only in 1954, "removing thereby the last remaining ob-

69 stacle to the enjoyment of complete equality of rights in the conduct of the

administrative affairs of the persian bahá'í community."

70 52-4 it is important
71 to note that the timing of the introduction of the provisions called for by
72 the interpretations of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá and the guardian in relation to the lo-
73 cal and National Spiritual Assemblies, rather than constituting a response
74 to some external condition or pressure, was dictated by the principle of progressive
implementation of the laws, as enjoined by bahá’u’lláh himself.

75 concerning the implementation of the laws, bahá’u’lláh wrote in one of
76 his Tablets:

77 52-4. mbw , p. 65.52.6a

52 7

53 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

54 91indeed the laws of god are like unto the ocean and the children of

men as fish, did they but know it. however, in observing them one

must exercise tact and wisdom. . . . one must guide mankind to the

ocean of true understanding in a spirit of love and tolerance.52-5

55 As mentioned earlier, the law regarding the membership of the universal

house of justice is embedded in the Text and has been merely restated

56 by the divinely appointed interpreters. it is therefore neither amenable to

57 change nor subject to speculation about some possible future condition.

with regard to the status of women, the important point for bahá’ís

58 to remember is that in face of the categorical pronouncements in bahá’í

59 Scripture establishing the equality of men and women, the ineligibility of

60 tute evidence of the superiority of men over women. it must also be borne

61 in mind that women are not excluded from any other international institu-

tion of the faith. They are found among the ranks of the hands of the

62 cause. They serve as members of the international Teaching center and as

63 continental counselors. And, there is nothing in the Text to preclude the

64 participation of women in such future international bodies as the Supreme

65 T ribunal.

66 Though at the present time it may be difficult for the believers to ap-

67 appreciate the reason for the circumscription of membership on the universal
68 house of justice to men, we call upon the friends to remain assured by
69 the master's promise that clarity of understanding will be achieved in due
70 course. The friends, both women and men, must accept this with faith that the
covenant of bahá'u'lláh will aid them and the institutions of his world
71 order to see the realization of every principle ordained by his unerring pen,
including the equality of men and women, as expounded in the writings
72 of the cause.
73 with loving bahá'í greetings,
74 52-5. kA, p. 6.52.7a
52 8
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53 messages from The Universal House of Justice
54 9253

First Meeting of New International Teaching Center

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]